



Patch Management Made Easy with Spacewalk

For a systems administrator controlling hundreds of Linux servers, not an uncommon scenario in an era of Big Data, it could be rather overwhelming if each one had to be patched, updated or required routine software management tasks done individually. Spacewalk is an open source patch management system. This article takes the reader through how to deploy it.

Spacewalk is an open source Linux server management software, a version of Red Hat's Satellite server. Red Hat is one of the big sponsors of Spacewalk and it is also community supported. It can support Red Hat, SUSE and Oracle Linux agents. Prior to version 2.3, Solaris agents were also supported. Spacewalk has been developed in a combination of Python, Perl and, in recent versions, Java too.

So how is it useful to you? I have 200 Linux servers in my office network, and I have to patch all of them twice in

a year. Manually copying and deploying the patch in all the servers is a time consuming process and effort-intensive too. To meet this challenge, Spacewalk can be used to deploy packages on selected servers or to deploy a set of patches from the central repository to many servers at one go. We can see the high level architecture of Spacewalk server in Figure 1. Spacewalk can be used to:

- Apply patches on many servers at one go
- Install a package/RPM to a group of servers